‘advanced reasoning skills’ and success in competitive exams in English, maths, medicine, railways and accounting—no doubt the surest ticket out of town for youngsters who acquire them.

Rhythms of Daily Life

I return the next day and wander the evocative ruins. What better place to feel the impermanence of all things? I try to fill in the monasteries’ missing walls, roofs, pillars—in vibrant colour. I imagine myself back within the quotidian life of the monks: the sounds of gongs, chants, greetings and discussions; cooking smells; unstitched yellow robes drying in the sun. In my mind’s eye, I see monks praying, chatting in the veranda, queuing for the toilet, and other mundane sounds and visuals of monastic life. I see them seated around a podium for a lecture. Does the teacher throw a piece of chalk at that dozing student in the back row?

Every morning, each student monk approaches his teacher, kneels before him and touches the ground with his forehead. The student inquires about his well-being and ‘offers him toothwood and puts a washing-basin and a towel at the side of his seat’. He ‘rubs the teacher’s body, folds his clothes, or sometimes sweeps the apartment and the yard’. He also brings clean drinking water for the teacher and offers other services as necessary. For his part, the teacher, besides teaching the expected topics, ‘inspects the pupil’s moral conduct, and warns him of defects and transgressions’, and in case of an illness ‘nurses him, supplies all the medicine needed, and pays attention to him as if he were his child’.[11]

‘It is considered meritorious to dig ponds,’ writes Yijing. Sal trees are planted along these ponds that ‘are fed by rainwater and are as clear as a pure river’. There are ‘more than ten great pools near the Nalanda monastery and there every morning a *ghanti* is sounded to remind the monks of the bathing-hour’.[12] Monks emerge in groups to bathe in these ponds with a cloth tied around their waists. According to Yijing, ‘Bathing without any cloth is contrary to the teachings of the Buddha’. These ponds were in fact carefully made tanks and the ruins still exist, filling up with rainwater during the monsoon.